

HOUSE JOINT RESOLUTION 1041

By Todd

A RESOLUTION to honor and congratulate Dr. Hyran E. Barefoot
on the celebration of his ninety-eighth birthday.

WHEREAS, it is the privilege of the members of this General Assembly to honor those exemplary citizens who have dedicated their lives to the cultivation of wisdom, the service of their communities, and the education of future generations; and

WHEREAS, Dr. Hyran E. Barefoot, the fourteenth president of Union University and a respected scholar, is celebrating the momentous occasion of his ninety-eighth birthday, marking nearly a century of faithful service, leadership, and influence; and

WHEREAS, a native of Mantee, Mississippi, Dr. Barefoot first arrived in Jackson in 1957 to join the Union University faculty, eventually adopting Jackson as his true home and the place where he and his late wife, Joyce, would raise their three daughters—Judy, June, and Jane; and

WHEREAS, Dr. Barefoot's tenure at Union University is a testament to his versatility and dedication, having served with distinction as a professor of religion and Greek, an academic dean, the university president from 1987 to 1996, and subsequently as chancellor; and

WHEREAS, known affectionately as the "Teacher President," Dr. Barefoot maintained his love for the classroom even while leading the university, continuing to teach students and famously remarking that his favorite courses were those with the "least amount of grading"; and

WHEREAS, under Dr. Barefoot's presidential leadership, Union University experienced a remarkable era of stability and growth, including record enrollments that doubled the student body, the expansion of the Penick Academic Complex, and the construction of the Hyran E. Barefoot Student Union Building, which stands as a physical testament to Dr. Barefoot's impact; and

WHEREAS, his unique personal style, characterized by his signature bow ties—a tradition he solidified in the 1970s—became a legendary symbol of his warm, approachable, and scholarly demeanor on campus; and

WHEREAS, Dr. Barefoot demonstrated a rare ability to engage others on equal footing, instilling in each acquaintance a genuine sense of importance and comfort, as evidenced when his sponsor, during his postsecondary education, confidently invited him to quail hunt on his family's farm in Weakley County—an invitation he graciously accepted; and

WHEREAS, even in retirement, Dr. Barefoot has remained a vital pillar of the university community, most recently championing the construction of "The Ethos Forum," a state-of-the-art facility for business and engineering, and generously funding the "Joyce Barefoot Lobby" in loving memory of his wife and Union's fourteenth First Lady; and

WHEREAS, Dr. Barefoot's life has been defined by a deep commitment to faith and learning, having influenced countless pastors, educators, and leaders who now serve across Tennessee and around the globe; now, therefore,

BE IT RESOLVED BY THE HOUSE OF REPRESENTATIVES OF THE ONE HUNDRED FOURTEENTH GENERAL ASSEMBLY OF THE STATE OF TENNESSEE, THE SENATE CONCURRING, that we hereby honor and congratulate Dr. Hyran E. Barefoot on the celebration of his ninety-eighth birthday and extend to him our best wishes for many happy returns of the day.

BE IT FURTHER RESOLVED, that an appropriate copy of this resolution be prepared for presentation with this final clause omitted from such copy and upon proper request made to the appropriate clerk, the language appearing immediately following the State seal appear without House or Senate designation.